

ISHMAM ABTAHI

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EDUCATION

University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA

August 2024 - May 2028

BS in Computer and Electrical Engineering | Minor: General Business | QuestBridge Scholar

Relevant Coursework: Data Structures & Algorithms, Intro to Cybersecurity, Computer Systems & Org, Digital Logic Design, Signals & Systems, Discrete Math

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- Cybersecurity & Networking: Network Segmentation | Firewalls (pf/OPNsense) | Suricata IDS | Penetration Testing | Nmap | BurpSuite | Splunk | Wireshark | Kali Linux | HackTheBox
- Software: Python | Java | JavaScript | React.js | Assembly | C | REST APIs | Ansible | Git | Linux
- Electrical/Hardware: CAD | KiCad | MATLAB | VHDL | Circuit Design | PCB Layout | Oscilloscope | Signal Analysis
- Certifications: CompTIA Security+ | AWS Certified AI Practitioner | Google Professional Cybersecurity | Microsoft Azure AZ-900 | AWS ML Foundation | Udacity Gen AI (AWS)

WORK EXPERIENCE

Security Engineering Intern

GuidePoint Security, Reston, VA

June 2026 - Present

- Designed and deployed a dual-firewall (OPNsense) network segmentation layer aligned with NIST Cybersecurity Framework least-privilege principles, isolating a deliberately vulnerable DMZ (Vulhub) from SIEM, Forensic, and User VLANs via directional pf rules on both firewalls
- Deployed Suricata as an inline IDS on the perimeter firewall's WAN interface, alerting on malicious traffic mapped to MITRE ATT&CK techniques via the Emerging Threats Open ruleset, and built a new Ansible firewall module to automate deployment across both firewalls
- Patched the team's Python deployment CLI to detect and configure OPNsense/FreeBSD hosts, and found and fixed 5 pre-deployment bugs that would have caused failed or locked-out deployments, catching them through review against official documentation before rollout

Researcher

Dart Labs (UVA Cybersecurity Research Lab), Charlottesville, VA

July 2026 - Present

- Conducting research with the Forensic Analysis and SOC Efficiency group on incident triage workflows and detection-pipeline performance for university security operations
- Applying digital forensics and log-analysis techniques to evaluate SOC tooling efficiency, contributing findings to ongoing lab research initiatives

Cybersecurity Analyst Intern

University of Virginia ITS, Charlottesville, VA

September 2025 - Present

- Analyzed 500+ weekly security events in Splunk, applying network forensics techniques to reduce false positives by 20% and support triage of 100+ security incidents in a production enterprise environment
- Coordinated with 6 interns on incident documentation and escalation across cloud and on-prem environments, improving response efficiency by 40% and cross-team coordination by 60%; partnered with 5 senior analysts to optimize detection and monitoring workflows

KEY PROJECTS

LLM Prompt Injection Benchmark

- Designed and built a prompt-injection vulnerability benchmark using 10 hand-crafted attacks spanning the OWASP LLM01:2025 taxonomy: direct/indirect injection, payload splitting, and obfuscation/multilingual attacks
- Built a deterministic, regex-based scoring pipeline detecting 3 compromise types (secret leakage, instruction hijacking, persona switching), deliberately avoiding LLM-as-judge scoring to eliminate the risk of the judge being manipulated
- Implemented and evaluated 2 prompt-hardening defenses (sandwich defense, untrusted-content delimiting), measuring a 33% reduction in overall attack success rate, up to 20% in the highest-risk category

SSH & Web Honeypot

- Built and deployed a low-interaction SSH and HTTP honeypot in Python on a Hostinger VPS to capture real-world attacker behavior against internet-facing services
- Logged 200+ connection attempts and 60+ credential-stuffing attempts over a 2-week period, identifying the top 10 credentials attempted and source IPs spanning 8+ countries
- Parsed captured payloads to identify recurring automated scanning behavior and built a Python log-analysis script to summarize attacker activity

EXTRACURRICULARS

Students Who Advance in Technology (SWAT), Charlottesville, VA

President

April 2025 - Present

- Founded and lead a 20+ member tech consulting organization partnering with 3 UVA departments per semester to deliver real automation and software solutions, from scoping through build to live presentation
- Led a team that built a computer lab for a local non-profit youth development center: sourced and refurbished 15+ recycled computers and set up the full lab environment (networking, OS imaging, software), now serving 50+ youth
- Delivered Data Science School partnerships for conference scheduling and expense report automation, and scoped a new UVA ITS partnership to build a RAG-based chatbot over 100+ pages of internal security documentation, targeting a 50% reduction in analyst documentation lookup time